

How to Use Your Experience to Save Time and Tuition

Are you experienced, workshop-educated, community-involved, and/or moderately traveled and still working toward your bachelor's degree? Write it down! You may be able to trade a nominal portfolio assessment fee for credit hours worth thousands at your college or university. I've helped many people who have saved time (by completing degree requirements through credit for prior learning rather than taking semester-long classes) and tuition expenses in exchange for documentation of their past experiences.

To get started, find out if your school has a credit for prior learning (CPL) program and more specifically, a portfolio assessment process. Next, get a copy of the guidelines. Then, prepare your portfolio. If you get stuck, look for available school resources like counselors or other faculty members to provide guidance.

Guidelines vary, but work, volunteer, and travel experiences, professional and technical training, and even hobbies may qualify as educational. The portfolio program tends to favor older adults with years of varied experience, but even a year or two of working between high school and college, or time off for traveling can qualify as prior learning.

Identify and document your experiential learning.

Work experience

Describe the company and your position(s), duties, and accomplishments.

Include quantifiable information. For example, list the sales for the company, business unit, territory, or assigned accounts, operating and capital budgets, and/or number of customers, manufacturing facilities, vendors, and distribution sites.

Present your accomplishments. What goals did you meet or exceed and under what challenging circumstances? What new programs did you design or introduce? What have you improved in your department, business unit, or company?

Explain what you learned. It could be as simple as "I learned how to increase sales by better assessing